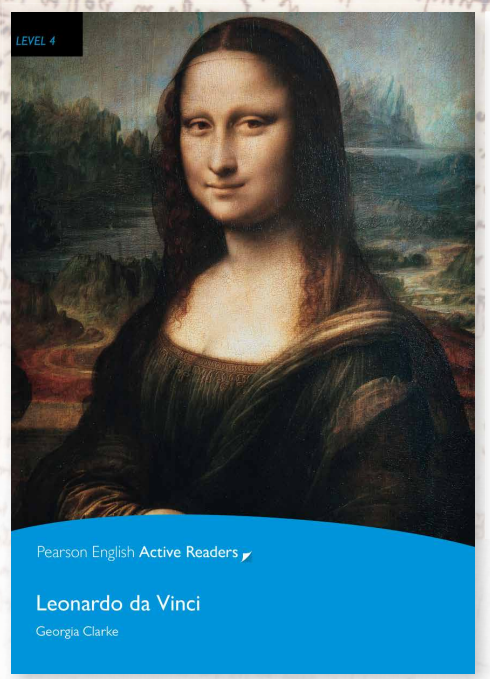
LEONARDO DA VINCI by Gerogia Clarke (B1–B2)



PREPARATION

1 **Look at the book cover and answer the questions.**

see

1 Describe the woman in the painting.
2 What can you see in the background?

think

3 What kinds of people had their portrait painted in the past?
4 What kinds of people have portraits painted now?

wonder

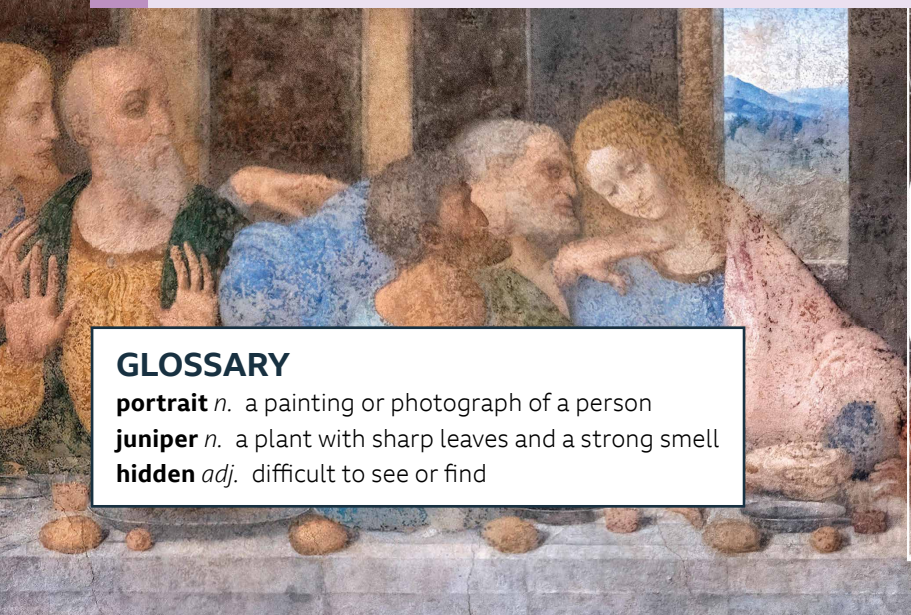
5 What do you think the woman in the painting was like?

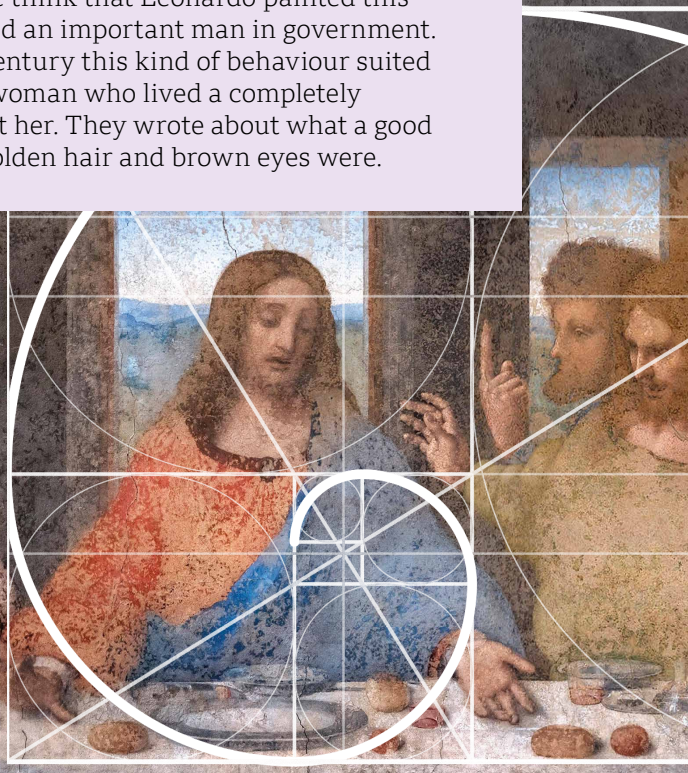
Leonardo the portrait painter

Leonardo was very interested in painting pictures of real people, especially their faces. He was famous for making **portraits** that people recognised. In 1503 one Florentine, Luca Ugolini, wrote to another, Niccolo Machiavelli, on the birth of Machiavelli's son: 'Congratulations! Your son looks just like you. Leonardo da Vinci could not do a better portrait.'

One of Leonardo's earliest portraits, of Ginevra de' Benci, was painted in Florence when Leonardo was in his twenties. In the landscape in the background, we can see how Leonardo gives you the sense of looking far out over countryside. The browns and greens disappear into the distance and become blue, which meets the light from the sky. For this, he used a method called, in Italian, sfumato. This is an effect almost like looking through smoke, where colours and lines disappear into each other.

Leonardo gives us help in guessing who the subject of the portrait is. The name Ginevra is very close to the Italian word ginepro, which means **juniper**, and we can see lots of this plant behind Ginevra's head. So Leonardo was making a play on words in the painting. Ginevra was a Florentine and the daughter of a very rich man. Some people think that Leonardo painted this portrait in 1474 when, aged sixteen or seventeen, she married an important man in government. Ginevra looks at us out of the painting and in the fifteenth century this kind of behaviour suited a wife more than an unmarried girl. But Ginevra was not a woman who lived a completely private and **hidden** life; a number of men wrote poems about her. They wrote about what a good and intelligent person she was and said how beautiful her golden hair and brown eyes were.





GLOSSARY

portrait *n.* a painting or photograph of a person
juniper *n.* a plant with sharp leaves and a strong smell
hidden *adj.* difficult to see or find

COMPREHENSION

2 LL7.01 **Listen and read the story behind one of Da Vinci's famous portraits. Choose the correct option, a), b), c) or d), to answer the questions.**

1 How do we know Leonardo was good at painting portraits?
- **a)** He was very interested in faces.
- **b)** People asked him to paint their children.
- **c)** At the time people said his portraits looked like the real people.
- **d)** He added a lot of details to the background of the portraits.

2 Which **two** things has Leonardo **not** given clues about in this painting?
- **a)** The woman's name.
- **b)** What she planted in her garden.
- **c)** If she was married or not.
- **d)** What people said about her.

LISTENING

3 LL7.02 **Listen to the story of another of his portraits and choose the correct option, a), b), c) or d), to answer the questions.**

GLOSSARY

ermine *n.* a small animal that lives in the countryside. Its special quality is that in the summer its fur is reddish-brown and in the winter it turns white, but its tail stays black.

symbol *n.* a thing or picture that means something else; for example, a flag is a symbol of a country

purity *n.* something that is good, clean or honest

1 Why did Leonardo paint her with an ermine in her arms?
- **a)** It was her favourite animal.
- **b)** He used it to show Cecilia was a very pure, good person.
- **c)** He liked the way it changed colour.
- **d)** He liked hunting them.

2 How did Cecilia feel about her portrait when she sent it to Isabella?
- **a)** She didn't think it looked like her anymore.
- **b)** She wanted a painting of herself when she was younger.
- **c)** She had never thought it looked like her.
- **d)** She didn't really like Leonardo's work.

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION

4 **Leonardo da Vinci wasn't only famous for his paintings. Find out more about his life and works.**

1 When was he born and when did he die?
2 Why is he known as the Renaissance Man?
3 What is his most famous portrait and when was it painted?
4 Why did he never make the Sforza horse sculpture that he planned in 1489?
5 What modern inventions did he design hundreds of years before they were actually invented?
6 What happened to his painting *The Virgin and Child with St Anne* in 1962 and then in 1987?

SPEAKING

5 **Work in small groups. Choose one of the things in the box and find out why it was important in Leonardo's life. Tell your group what you have found out.**

The Last Supper	Michelangelo
King Francois I	Francesco Melzi

CLIL CONNECTION
Biology

6 **Leonardo's paintings and sculptures had so much life in them because he studied anatomy. He examined dead bodies to see how they worked. The words in the box are body parts. Which ones are bones (B) and which are muscles (M)?**

deltoid phalanges Achilles tendon
scapula sartorius tibia mandible
supinator

